CHAPTER 2

KINGS FARMERS AND TOWNS

CHAPTER ESSENCE AT A GLANCE:
Master early historical India (c. 600 BCE - 600 CE): Sixteen Mahajanapadas, rise of Magadha, Mauryan imperial administration, Ashoka's Dhamma edicts, and numismatic epigraphy.

4 CORE PRINCIPLES TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

• **Sixteen Mahajanapadas and Rise of Magadha:** 6th century BCE marked second urbanization with iron technology and punch-marked coins; Magadha emerged preeminent due to fertile Gangetic alluvium, iron deposits of Rajgir, and elephant warfare.

• **Mauryan Imperial Administration:** Founded by Chandragupta Maurya (321 BCE); governed via five major political centers (Pataliputra, Taxila, Ujjayini, Tosali, Suvarnagiri) and six administrative committees described by Megasthenes.

• **Ashoka and Dhamma Propagation:** Emperor Ashoka embraced Buddhism following Kalinga War (261 BCE); inscribed rock and pillar edicts in Brahmi and Kharosthi promoting social ethics, religious tolerance, and appointed Dhamma Mahamattas.

• **Gupta Age and Divine Kingship:** Rulers legitimized authority by claiming divine status (Kushana Devaputra); Gupta epigraphy (Samudragupta's Prayaga Prashasti by Harishena) exalted imperial conquests and land grants.

ESSENTIAL HISTORICAL CHRONOLOGIES & THEMES

$$\text{Magadhan Superiority} \iff \text{Iron Mines (Weapons)} + \text{Gangetic Alluvium} + \text{Forest War Elephants}$$

Three Strategic Factors of Imperial Hegemony

$$\text{Mauryan Centers} \to \{\text{Pataliputra, Taxila, Ujjayini, Tosali, Suvarnagiri}\}$$

Five Imperial Administrative Headquarters

$$\text{Ashokan Dhamma Edicts} \iff \text{Brahmi and Kharosthi Script} \to \text{Non-Violence and Religious Harmony}$$

Pan-Indian Moral Governance Philosophy

$$\text{James Prinsep Breakthrough (1838)} \iff \text{Deciphered Brahmi and Kharosthi} \to \text{Identified Piyadassi (Ashoka)}$$

Epigraphical Foundation of Early Indian Historiography

CRUCIAL EXAM PRECAUTIONS & VALUATION RUBRIC SECRETS

• **Alert:** James Prinsep deciphered Brahmi and Kharosthi scripts in 1838, revealing that the title 'Devanampiya Piyadassi' (Beloved of the Gods) referred to King Ashoka.

• **Alert:** Magadha's initial capital was Rajagriha ('House of the King'), surrounded by fortified hills; later in the 4th century BCE, the capital was shifted to Pataliputra (Patna) on the Ganga.

• **Alert:** Ashoka's Dhamma was not a new formal religion; it was a universal moral and civic code encompassing non-violence, respect for elders, and generosity to brahmins and ascetics.

HIGH-YIELD CENTUM QUESTIONS & STEP-BY-STEP EXPLANATIONS

1. Explain any three factors responsible for the rise of Magadha as the most powerful Mahajanapada. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **1. Agricultural Fertility:** Located in the fertile Gangetic alluvium with high rainfall, ensuring abundant agricultural surplus to sustain large standing armies. **[1 Mark]**

• **2. Iron Ore Mines:** Controlled rich iron deposits in nearby Jharkhand, providing raw material for manufacturing sharp agricultural implements and lethal military weapons. **[1 Mark]**

• **3. Elephants and Waterway Communication:** Dense forests provided war elephants (an indispensable military wing), while the Ganga and Son rivers provided fast, economical communication and trade. **[1 Mark]**

2. Describe the administrative machinery of the Mauryan Empire as recorded by Megasthenes. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Centralized Military Board:** Megasthenes described a grand military committee of 30 members divided into 6 sub-committees of 5 members each. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Six Military Wings:** (1) Navy; (2) Transport and provisions; (3) Infantry; (4) Cavalry; (5) War chariots; (6) War elephants. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Provincial Control:** Governed through five major provincial centers situated along trade routes, headed by royal princes (Kumaras) as viceroys. **[1 Mark]**

3. What was Ashoka's Dhamma? State any two of its core teachings and mention how he propagated it. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Concept:** A universal ethical code promoted by Ashoka across his empire after renouncing war following the Kalinga conflict in 261 BCE. **[1 Mark]**

• **Core Teachings:** Respect for parents, elders, and teachers; kindness to servants and slaves; religious tolerance; non-violence (ahimsa) towards animals and living beings. **[1 Mark]**

• **Propagation Method:** Inscribed on major rock edicts and polished stone pillars, and appointed special officers known as 'Dhamma Mahamattas' to disseminate moral teachings. **[1 Mark]**

4. Discuss the significance of James Prinsep's contribution to Indian epigraphy. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Breakthrough in 1838:** Deciphered Brahmi and Kharosthi, the earliest scripts used in ancient Indian inscriptions and coins. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Identification of Ashoka:** Recognized that inscriptions mentioning 'Piyadassi' (Pleasant to behold) and 'Devanampiya' referred to Emperor Ashoka, opening the scientific study of early Indian political history. **[1.5 Marks]**

5. What is the Prayaga Prashasti? Who composed it and in praise of which king? [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Meaning:** A celebrated eulogistic Sanskrit inscription on the Allahabad pillar praising royal conquests and divine qualities. **[1 Mark]**

• **Author and King:** Composed by court poet Harishena in praise of Gupta emperor Samudragupta. **[1 Mark]**

6. Why were land grants (agrahara) made by kings in early historical India? [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Reasons:** To extend agricultural cultivation into forested frontiers, win over religious brahmins and monasteries, and project political authority amidst weakening central rule. **[2 Marks]**